

CHAPTER 9

Young Love and Money

You worked like a dog through school. You held a part-time job, graduated, never moved back home—or if you did, your time there was short and strategic. Now you're on your own, tackling rent, your student loan (not car payments, because you're servicing debt and you live close to work, right? so you don't have a car), and you're about to start full-time employment in your first postgrad job. So why did you quit that bartending gig? You've been working there three, four nights a week all through school, but you could have gone down to one or two nights a week and still put in those forty hours as an office intern or an editorial assistant in the newsroom. It's great that you got that entry-level position at that ad agency, but it isn't going to pay much for a couple of years.

And it's during this time that you could begin to fall prey to a lot of unnecessary consumer spending. That's how it happens. Your income goes up a little, you suddenly feel flush. You stop putting money into your Secret 10 because you're suddenly buying shoes you can't really afford. And is that you throwing your credit card down on the table, treating your four friends to a dinner you can't afford? Why did you do that? You think you have money because you're finally earning it. Earning money is not the same thing as having money. *As long as you have consumer debt, you are not accumulating anything.*

I want to be very clear here. If your goal is to pay down that student debt as quickly as possible so you can begin to build a decent nest egg, or to save for that down payment on a house, it starts now. You saw the compound interest charts. You know that the more you